

Drosera Obscura

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ABSTRACT

Drosera Obscura is an interactive installation that explores the evolutionary journey of a carnivorous plant thriving in the Pacific Northwest after humanity's departure. We imagine the remnants of human existence—plastics, metals, and machinery—become integral elements in the life and ecosystem of this resilient organism. This work incorporates aspects of touch, smell, sound, and animatronics to create an immersive experience.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Applied computing** → Arts and humanities; Media arts.

KEYWORDS

Unreal Engine, Virtual reality, Experiences

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1 INTRODUCTION

In the eons following the departure of humankind, amidst the tranquil expanse of a bog nestled along the windswept shores of the

Pacific Northwest, unfolds the quiet saga of the *Drosera obscura*—a tale woven with threads of adaptation and symbiosis. This curious entity emerges from the lineage of the *Drosera rotundifolia*, a testament to the resilience of life in the face of ecological upheaval. Evolving among the remnants of human civilization, it embraces the relics, weaving them into the fabric of its existence.

A carnivorous marvel, it thrives in the nutrient-poor soil by ensnaring and digesting unwary insects using attractive scents and sticky secretions. Curiously, *Obscura* has repurposed this mucilage to not only imprison prey, but also to fuse the microplastics that litter its boggy domain, creating a corallite home to fortify against the elements and the relentless march of ants.

Forgotten contraptions also find new life under the plant's touch, as rusted machinery from cranberry harvests interlaces its casing. A hollowed shell creates an ethereal voice, attracting prey while the clicking cracks of gears inform of friend and foe. Phototropic movements blend with a newfound knack for harnessing the winds, propelling *Obscura* with each gust. With the onset of autumn it retreats into a hibernaculum, its battle tested shell falling to the earth. Come the stirrings of spring, the bud yields to the burgeoning life within. It blossoms, entwining into the home of its ancestor.

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